

In-depth Interviews for Lay Individuals

Sampling Scheme: In-depth Interviews for Lay Individuals

Sample Size: N=40-50 (20-25 couples). This is benchmarked with recommendation of Dworkin, 2012 which allow the responses to more likely reach saturation and redundancy, and if not then at least to allow for enough data to “clarify relationships between conceptual categories and identify variation in processes, and [maximize] the chances that negative cases and hypothetical negative cases have been explored in the data” (p. 1320)

Countries France, Brazil, Philippines, Turkey, US

Potentially relevant dimensions:

- 1.) Relationship length
- 2.) SES/ Educ Level
- 3.) Sexual Orientation
- 4.) Satisfaction level
- 5.) Monogamous vs. non-monogamous
- 6.) Ethnicity (parent’s nationality)
- 7.) Age of individual
- 8.) Personality characteristics of individual (including attachment style)
- 9.) Etc. [schema from family modeling, media depictions of relationships, cultural conceptions of romance and romantic relationships etc.]

Modified Targeted Chain Referral Method

The key objective of the sampling scheme is to have a principled way of exploring relationship quality conceptualization across couples in different cultures. How people conceptualize relationship quality is likely to be influenced by many individual and dyadic characteristics: relationship length, SES, Sexual Orientation, satisfaction level, relationship structure, ethnicity, age, personality characteristics, cultural scripts and so on. In a sense this sampling scheme is a trade-off: how do we explore as much as we can given the sample size (N=50)? Adding in all the different ‘diversity’ dimensions would not be supported by the current sample size & resources. Thus, the current variables (particularly relationship length, satisfaction level, and SES proxy) that are factored in to the sampling scheme are educated judgements about how to expand the possibility space, while following a feasible and more-or-less systematic approach, using a quasi-stratified, purposive sampling that would be selected through a modified targeted, chain-referral method [See *Potential Matrix* and *Modified Targeted Chain Referral Method*]. Note that the relationship bins are not equal, but this categorization is an educated judgment of how to maximize variance in the responses of the participants (i.e., that those within categories share more similar experiences that across the categories)

Potential Matrix

	Below / Equal to Median Income		Equal / Above to Median Income	
	Low satisfaction	High satisfaction	Low satisfaction	High satisfaction
<1 year				
1-<5 years				
5-<10 years				
10-<20 years				
20> years				
LGBT*				
Non-monogamous *				
LGBT & Non-monogamous couples are “floating”, and will not be completely crossed across length & satisfaction: per community, 1-2 LGBT couples will be interviewed, and 1 non-monogamous couple will be interviewed regardless of length or relationship satisfaction				

Building from previous works of Petersen & Valdez (2005, “Using Snowball-Based Methods in Hidden Populations to Generate a Randomized Community Sample of Gang-Affiliated Adolescents”), as well as from respondent-driven sampling (Heckathorn, 1997; 2002) and targeted sampling (Braunstein, 1993)

The sampling scheme to be used for this study will be a targeted, chain-referral approach modified to have buffer nodes / nominators.

Among a roster of potential dimensions, satisfaction, relationship length, relative SES, and orientation are chosen as initial dimensions for which to more-or-less systematically explore the possibility space of the conceptualization of relationship quality (see *Potential Matrix*). With N=25 couples, this matrix will be randomly allocated to the data collectors per country (for this section we’ll assume 3 data collectors are available per country).

More concretely: 1.) a close contact (“Nominator”) of a data collector within the country will be asked to list 3 contacts that they believe will fit the profile of the first allocated cell of the matrix (have been together less than 1 year, satisfied, earning above median income*). One will be randomly selected to be contacted for the interview. If they refuse, or are uninterested, there will be a random selection again from the remaining two. If none of the initial 3 contacts are interested, another nominator will be tapped.

Once the interview is finished with the interviewee, they will be kindly asked to list two nominators who each will independently give three contacts that they believe will fit the next cell of the matrix (ex. Have been together for 1 to 4 years, unsatisfied, earning below median income). Similarly, one will be randomly selected from the 6 contacts, with the remaining five to be contacted in case of refusal. This procedure will be iterated until the data collector has finished their allocation of the potential matrix (8 or 9 couples per data collector for 3 data collectors in the country).

This sampling strategy is midway between convenience sampling and true random sampling. It allows for outsized reach, not just within the researchers' network but also the branching network of the participants and nominators (practically leveraging the network, of the network, of the network...). Buffer nodes or "Nominators" serve multiple purposes 1.) One is it allows for further reach, but also, it 2.) minimizes the chance of peer-identification from transcript portions that will later be publicized (and gives plausible deniability to any one couple that they were not contacted, as is statistically likely), and 3.) It greatly lessens the likelihood that the interviewed couples know each other, and thus reduces the potential anxiety of comparison, or inquiries about the experiences of the other couples.**

In this strategy, rapport with interviewee and the nominators are paramount.

*Note that these contacts may err (they might nominate a couple that they believe to be satisfied, but the actual interview might show that they are not; or they might misjudge their relative SES etc.). However, this is not too much of a concern as the matrix and the sampling scheme is the launching point for the exploration of the conceptualization of romantic relationship quality among a diverse subset of each country, but is not in itself a strict plan for stratification

**Couples listed by the nominator will be asked if the interviewee (who nominated the nominator) knows the couples, and will be encouraged to provide couples that are not known or are not in the same social groups as the previous interviewee.

INTERVIEW GUIDE LAY INDIVIDUALS

Domain	ID	Questions	Rationale / Comments	Time estimate
		Good day! Thank you again for participating in this interview. As mentioned over email/text, we want to know more about your views on romantic relationships, and we believe your experience and perspective would bring much to the project. Before we begin, is it alright if we record this interview? We will only use it for transcription/note-taking		
Demographics	1	How old are you?		5
	2	How long have you been together with your partner?		
	3	Do you have children?		
	4	Who lives in the household?		
	5	What is your main source of income? What is your current job?		
	6	How would you like us to address your partner? (boyfriend, partner, lover etc.)		
General / Context-Setting	7	Can you tell me about your love story?	Rapport + Context-setting	5-10
	7.1	<i>If unanswered, probe:</i> when did you meet, how did the relationship develop?		
Relationship Quality	8	How would you compare the quality of your relationship, compared to that of your friends' relationships? [<i>If unanswered</i>] Why do you say so?	<i>NOTE FOR INTERVIEWERS: If interviewee asks what relationship quality means, throw the question back and explain that you are interested in what they understand it to be</i>	3
	9	Can I also ask how many romantic partners you've had in the past?		3-5

		Now, how would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to your previous relationships? <i>[If unanswered]</i> Why would you say so?		
	10	For you, what makes a relationship high quality? Low quality? <i>[If unanswered]</i> Why do you say so? <i>IF, they use adjectives like STRONG, HEALTHY, CLOSE, INTIMATE etc., probe:</i>	<i>[NOTE: take note of the words they naturally use re: relationship quality, look out for "strong", "close", "healthy", "good", "fulfilling", "satisfying", "resilient"]</i>	5
	10.1	So would you say that high-quality relationships are [ADJECTIVE USED ex. "Close relationships, strong relationships], Can you tell me more about how one knows that one is in a [ADJECTIVE USED] relationship?		
	10.2	<i>Further probe:</i> [When would you say your relationship was [ADJECTIVE USED]? When was it least [ADJECTIVE USED]?]		
	11	For you, what are the most important things in a relationship? <i>[if unanswered]</i> Why do you say so?	<i>Interviewer note: if applicable, say "You touched on some of these things in your previous answers, but I want to ask again, for you what are the most important things in a relationship?"</i>	4-5
Conceptualization of Love	12	For you, what is love?		5
	13	How important is love in a relationship?		2
	14	How do you know that your partner loves you?		4
Conflict	15	What would you say are challenges in your relationship?		5
	16 16.1 16.2 16.3	<i>If not answered:</i> Do you and your partner fight? <i>Probe:</i> How often would you say these fights are? <i>Probe:</i> What are these fights about? <i>Probe:</i> How do you resolve these fights?		5

Relationship Maintenance	17	Aside from <i>[conflict resolution response]</i> what are other ways that you maintain your relationship?		5
Occupational Latitude	18	Would you say that the relationship is good for you? Why? <i>IF they mention about being supported in goals or day-to-day functioning, probe for concrete examples</i>	<i>Note occupational latitude: notion of being able to achieve your goals / have regulated day-to-day functioning because of the relationship or the partner</i>	
Identity	19 20 20.1 21.1	Did the relationship change you? In what way? What about your partner, did they change during the relationship? <i>IF they don't understand the original wording: Is the person you were before the relationship the same as the person you are now? [if unanswered] why?</i> Is your partner the same before the relationship as they are now? <i>[if unanswered] why?</i>		10
Relationship Safety	22	Do you feel safe in the relationship? Why do you say so? <i>Probe concrete examples of feelings of safety/unsafety</i>	<i>Note, relationship safety: notion of being able to open up to your partner about your experiences, thoughts, identity without fear of judgment or reprisal. Also the expectation that the other will offer comfort and caring in times of danger or distress.</i> <i>NOTE: if they ask if physical or emotional, answer both or in general</i>	

Partner Responsive ness	23	Response Categories: <table> <tr> <td>1</td> <td>2</td> <td>3</td> <td>4</td> <td>5</td> <td>6</td> <td>7</td> <td>8</td> <td>9</td> </tr> <tr> <td>Not at all true</td> <td></td> <td>Somewhat true</td> <td></td> <td>Moderately true</td> <td></td> <td>Very true</td> <td></td> <td>Completely true</td> </tr> </table> My partner usually: <u>General Items</u> ... really listens to me.* ... is responsive to my needs.* From 1 “Not at all true” to 9 “completely true”, if I were to ask “My partner usually really listens to me” what would be your answer?	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	Not at all true		Somewhat true		Moderately true		Very true		Completely true	[Interviewers, please visually present the Likert scale]	7
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9													
	Not at all true		Somewhat true		Moderately true		Very true		Completely true													
	24	What about if I were to ask “My partner usually is responsive to my needs?” From 1 to 9?																				
25	Why did you answer [X] for item 1? Can you give us concrete examples of when this happened? Why [X] and not, [X-1 or X+1]?																					
26	Why did you answer [X] for item 2? Can you give us concrete examples of when this happened? Why [X] and not, [X-1 or X+1]?																					
Sex	27	I hope you don’t mind if I ask, and feel free to say if this is too sensitive for you to share, but I also wanted to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple. These days, how often do you have sex?	Note for interviewer: if they mentioned sex/physical affection earlier on the interview, mention that here “I hope you dont mind if we ask, since you mentioned earlier that sex is important in a relationship...”	10																		
	28	How satisfied are you with your sex life? Why do you say so?	[Note: Loop back to answer of important things in relationship -- ask why they believe sex is important or not]																			

Global Satisfaction	29	In general, how satisfied are you with your relationship? • Completely dissatisfied • Very dissatisfied • Somewhat dissatisfied • Unsure /Neutral • Somewhat satisfied • Very satisfied • Completely satisfied	<i>Interviewer note: Visually present the response options</i>	12
	29 A	<i>IF: they answer completely or very dissatisfied</i> If -10 is completely dissatisfied, and 0 is not at all dissatisfied, how would you rate your satisfaction with your relationship?		
	29 B	<i>IF: they answer completely or very satisfied</i> If 0 is not at all satisfied and 10 was completely satisfied, how would you rate your satisfaction with your relationship?		
	29 C	<i>If they answer Unsure/Neutral</i> If -10 was completely dissatisfied and 10 was completely satisfied, how would you rate your satisfaction with your relationship?		
	30	Why did you answer [numeric response]? <i>Probe if unanswered: can you let me know why [NR] not [NR-1 or NR+1]?</i> <i>Probe if unanswered: Did the relationship fulfill your expectations</i>		
Summary		Interviewer note: We are close to wrapping up. I would just like to summarize what have conversed about in the past hour: [short summary per domain here] Was that right? Is there anything you'd like to add?	Rapport	
Data Notice		Thank you so much! Now before we end, I want to talk to you about how we will handle the data. As a research project, we want to be as		

		ethically transparent as possible, and so we I wanted to know which data sharing option you are most comfortable with Option #1 is that transcript portions can be shared, none of which can be identified to you. So the deidentified transcript can also be read by other researchers. Option #2, If you were bolder, another option is that the whole transcript can be shared removed of sensitive and overly identifying details, so it will be anonymized. Although in this option, there is very minimal chance that someone who knows you well can piece together the details in the transcript and narrow down who among their colleagues they believe it is. Although again, no sensitive information will be shared Of the two options, which are you more comfortable with?		
Nomination		Thank you so much again for participating in this study. I would like you to know that this is also being done in the Philippines, Brazil, Turkey, France and the US. For this study to be successful, there is also one more thing that we will ask you, if that's okay for you. Can you recommend two close people in your life as a nominator? We would ask them for additional couples that might be interested in this study, but we'll be asking them for couples that you don't know or interact with. This way we can get as diverse a network as we can get. Is that okay for you? Thank you! We'll be contacting them today or tomorrow, we'll also be grateful if you can give them a heads up so they don't block us when we contact them. Thank you!		

In-depth Interviews with Relationship Therapists

Sampling Scheme: In-depth Interviews with Relationship Therapists

Sample Size: at least N=25 relationship therapists. This sample size is benchmarked with the recommendation of Dworkin, 2012, which would allow the responses from the interview to more likely reach saturation and redundancy, and if not, then at least allow for enough data to “clarify relationships between conceptual categories and identify variation in processes, and [maximize] the chances that negative cases and hypothetical negative cases have been explored in the data” (p. 1320)

Inclusion Criteria: Invitations will be sent to currently practicing relationship therapists primarily through the networks of the proposing authors. Among the existing contacts, the sample will purposively diversify across 1.) therapeutic modality (cognitive behavioral couple’s therapy, emotion-focused therapy, gottman therapy etc.) 2.) client profiles (heterosexual, LGBT, non-monogamous couples), and 3.) across different cultures/countries

General directions for the In-Depth Interview: The in-depth interview will explore the therapists’ conceptualization of relationship quality. how they use existing relationship scales in their work. what they would look for in a newly developed relationship quality scale (and how this would fit into their practice), and explore other measurement and assessment dynamics as it relates to their practice. Summary descriptions of their therapeutic approach will also be asked (i.e., typical duration of sessions, typical presenting issues among clients, etc.)

The goal of this phase of the research is to 1.) explicate the conceptualization of relationship quality among therapists, 2.) check whether current assessment and measurement procedures is coherent with this conceptualization (especially given the poor state of measurement in the field, Flake et al., 2017; and in relationship quality in particular, Ribotta et al., 2022) and 3.) provide concrete directions for the clinical utility of the scale to be developed. Additionally, this also presents an opportunity to pitch a collaboration for the next parts of the PhD project (in-depth interview with lay individuals, scale development, and scale validation)

Interview Guide for Relationship Therapists

	Questions	Rationale
1	Good morning! how are you? Thank you again for participating in this interview. Again, we <i>do</i> believe your experience and perspective would bring much to the project. Before we begin, is it alright if we record this interview? It will just be for transcription for note-taking, but I will not be keeping the video.	Rapport
2	To start, I just want to get a better sense of your practice, [repeat here any information that is publicly available: Specific modality, client profile, country of origin] Is that correct? IF unknown modality: What kind of couple's therapy would you say you primarily provide? (CBCT, EFT, Family Systems) IF unknown client profile: Are there specific types of couples that you provide your services to? IF uncertain country of practice: And your provide services to couples in [country], correct?	Information about clinical practice (+ clinical utility later on)
3	When clients come to you, what is usually the presenting issue or the reason that they seek your service?	Information about clinical practice
4	Do you do a formal assessment? Why or why not? How do you do the assessment and how long does it take? Probe: Are there relationship scales that you use? When do you use these scales? How does this fit into the assessment? Probe: How informative do you find these scales to be? Probe: Do you have any challenges when using these scales?	Information about clinical practice

	Probe: If its alright with you, can I ask how much these scales cost you?	
5	Across the years, different therapists and different researchers have characterized the construct of relationship quality quite differently from each other. I wanted to get your view about it, for you, what is relationship quality?	Therapist conceptualization of relationship quality
6	For you, what differentiates couples with high relationship quality and those with low relationship quality? Probe: In your professional experience, what are the most important things in a (high-quality) relationship? Why do you say so? Probe: And you also said that ____ (strong, close, healthy) etc. What does this kind of relationship look like? What is a relationship that is not (strong, close, healthy) look like?	
7	Does how you conceptualize relationships often differ from how your clients conceptualize relationships? In what way? Does this matter for therapy?	
8	The relationship is a complex system, it involves love, sex, identity, relationship maintenance, conflicts, responsiveness, satisfaction etc. During therapy, how do you decide which one to focus on or which one in the complex system to target?	Therapist conceptualization of relationship quality
9	How do you determine when to end the couple's therapy? [If not answered] Probe: What are the usual treatment goals? Probe: From start to finish, typically how long are the sessions? And how often are the sessions scheduled (once a week? Once every two weeks?)	Information about clinical practice
11	We are currently developing a relationship quality scale that hopefully better represents the relationship as a complex system, that would help therapists in treatment planning and evaluation, how interested would you be in this scale? Personally, what would you be looking for in this newly developed relationship scale? How can we make sure that this scale would be useful in your practice?	Clinical utility

	Probe: We are planning to carefully develop and validate this scale over the course of two years, after which we will be selling it for 500 euros (lifetime license, unlimited copies) -- until we recoup the development costs after which it will be free. Would this cost be feasible for you? Why or why not? Probe (if they believe it to be too expensive): If every license brought donates two licenses to therapists in low-and-middle income countries, would this be more appealing to you?	
12	Would you be interested to collaborate on the development of the scale?	[Send updated proposal]
13	Thank you so much! Now before we end, I want to talk to you about how we will handle the data. I wanted to know which data sharing option you are most comfortable with. One option is transcript portions can be shared, none of which can be identified to you. Another option is that the whole transcript can be shared removed of sensitive and overly identifying details, so it will be anonymized. Although in this option, there is very minimal chance that someone who knows you well professionally can piece together the details in the transcript (country, therapy practice etc.) and narrow down who among their colleagues they believe it is. Although again, no sensitive information will be shared. If you're not comfortable with any of these options, let me know and we can discuss other data sharing options.	